

Windows Explorer

Lesson 20 — Files, Paths and File Operations

JKSSB Computer Awareness

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What Windows Explorer Is

- ▶ **Windows Explorer** is the file-management program of the Windows operating system.
- ▶ In Windows 10 and Windows 11 it is called **File Explorer**.
- ▶ Its program file is **explorer.exe**.
- ▶ It lets you browse drives, folders, and files, and perform operations such as copy, move, rename, and delete.

The one idea

File Explorer is the window through which the user sees and manages all the files stored on the computer.

The Parts of the Window

- ▶ **Navigation pane** (left): shows the tree of drives and folders.
- ▶ **Address bar** (top): shows the full **path** of the current folder.
- ▶ **File list** (centre): shows the contents of the open folder.
- ▶ **Ribbon / Command bar** (top): holds the tabs for actions such as New, Cut, Copy, Paste, Delete, and View.
- ▶ **Search box**: finds files inside the current folder.

Drives, Folders, Subfolders, Files

- ▶ A **drive** is a storage location named by a drive letter, such as **C:** (hard disk) or **E:** (USB drive).
- ▶ A **folder** (also called a **directory**) is a container that holds files and other folders.
- ▶ A folder inside another folder is a **subfolder**.
- ▶ A **file** is a single item of stored data, such as a document, image, or program.

Nesting

A folder can contain subfolders, and each subfolder can contain more subfolders — this forms a tree of folders.

The File Path

- ▶ A **path** is the complete address that tells Windows exactly where a file or folder is located.
- ▶ Parts are separated by a **backslash** (\).
- ▶ Example: **C:\Users\Student\Documents\report.docx**
 - ▶ C: is the drive
 - ▶ Users, Student, Documents are folders
 - ▶ report.docx is the file name with extension
- ▶ The top-most folder of a drive is the **root folder**.

File Names and Extensions

- ▶ A file name is written as **name.extension**, for example **report.docx**.
- ▶ The **extension** is the letters after the last dot; it tells Windows which program opens the file and what **format** the data is in.
- ▶ Common extensions: **.txt** (text), **.docx** (Word document), **.xlsx** (Excel workbook), **.pptx** (PowerPoint), **.pdf** (portable document), **.jpg** (image), **.exe** (program).

Trap alert

An **extension** is not the same as a **format**. **.png** is an extension; **PNG** is the format (TRM-09, TRAP-34).

Hidden Files and File Attributes

- ▶ Every file and folder has **attributes** — properties that control how Windows treats it.
- ▶ The main attributes are **Read-only**, **Hidden**, **System**, and **Archive**.
- ▶ A **hidden file** or folder has the **Hidden** attribute set, so it is not shown by default.
- ▶ To see hidden items: **View** tab → **Show** → **Hidden items**.

Why hidden files exist

Windows marks important system files as hidden so that users do not move or delete them by accident.

Properties

- ▶ **Properties** show the details of a selected file, folder, or drive.
- ▶ Open them with **Alt + Enter** or by **right-click → Properties**.
- ▶ A file's Properties show its **type (format)**, **location (path)**, **size**, **date created** and **date modified**, and its **attributes**.
- ▶ A drive's Properties show **used space** and **free space**.

Selecting Files

- ▶ **Single file**: click it once.
- ▶ **Contiguous range**: click the first file, hold **Shift**, then click the last file.
- ▶ **Non-contiguous files**: hold **Ctrl** and click each file.
- ▶ **All files**: **Ctrl** + **A**.

Office desktop example

To copy three separate invoices, hold **Ctrl** and click each one — a **Ctrl+click** adds a file to the current selection.

Copy

- ▶ **Copy** makes a **duplicate** of the selected item; the **original stays in place**.
- ▶ Method 1: **Ctrl + C**, then open the destination and press **Ctrl + V** (paste).
- ▶ Method 2: right-click → **Copy**, then **Paste** in the destination.
- ▶ **Ctrl + drag** also copies, even within the same drive.

Remember

Copy leaves the original file untouched and creates a second copy.

Move

- ▶ **Move** shifts the selected item to a new place; the **original is removed** from the old location.
- ▶ Fastest method: **Ctrl + X** (cut), open the destination, then **Ctrl + V** (paste).
- ▶ **Dragging** a file to another folder on the **same drive** moves it.
- ▶ Dragging to a folder on a **different drive** copies it.

Cut is a move

Cut + Paste is the standard way to move a file. Nothing is copied; the file is relocated.

Rename

- ▶ **Rename** changes only the **name** of a file or folder; the contents are not changed.
- ▶ Method 1: select the item and press **F2**, type the new name, and press **Enter**.
- ▶ Method 2: right-click → **Rename**.
- ▶ Changing the part after the dot may change the file's type, so be careful with the extension.

Shortcut

F2 is the keyboard shortcut for Rename.

Delete and the Recycle Bin

- ▶ Pressing the **Delete** key moves the selected item to the **Recycle Bin**.
- ▶ The **Recycle Bin** is a special folder that temporarily stores deleted items.
- ▶ An item in the Recycle Bin can be **restored** to its original location with **Restore**.
- ▶ **Empty Recycle Bin** deletes everything in it permanently.

Recycle Bin vs Permanent Deletion

Point	Recycle Bin (Delete)	Permanent deletion
Shortcut	Delete	Shift + Delete
Recoverable	Yes, restore possible	No, cannot be restored
Stored where	Recycle Bin folder	Removed from disk

Permanent deletion can also happen by emptying the Recycle Bin or by deleting from a USB drive or network drive, which bypasses the Bin.

Key Keyboard Shortcuts

Action	Shortcut	Action
Copy	Ctrl + C	Ctrl + A — Select all
Cut (move)	Ctrl + X	F2 — Rename
Paste	Ctrl + V	Delete — To Recycle Bin
Undo	Ctrl + Z	Shift+Delete — Permanent delete
Properties	Alt + Enter	F5 — Refresh

Drag-and-Drop Behaviour

- ▶ **Drag** within the **same drive**: the file is **moved**.
- ▶ **Drag** between **different drives**: the file is **copied**.
- ▶ **Ctrl + drag**: always **copies**, even in the same drive.
- ▶ **Shift + drag**: always **moves**, even across drives.

Trap alert

Same-drive drag **moves**; different-drive drag **copies**. Do not reverse these two.

Trap Alert: File Operations to Keep Straight

- ▶ **Copy** leaves the original; **move** (Cut + Paste) removes it.
- ▶ The **Delete** key sends a file to the Recycle Bin; it does not erase it at once.
- ▶ **Shift + Delete** deletes permanently and **bypasses** the Recycle Bin.
- ▶ Deleting from a **USB drive** or **network drive** also bypasses the Recycle Bin.
- ▶ An **extension** is not the **format** (TRM-09).

Lesson 20: Recall

- ▶ **Windows Explorer** (now **File Explorer**) is the Windows file manager; its program is **explorer.exe**.
- ▶ A **drive** holds **folders**; folders contain **subfolders** and **files**; the **path** gives a file's full location.
- ▶ The **extension** after the dot shows the file type; an extension is not the same as a format.
- ▶ **Hidden** is a file attribute; see hidden items via **View** → **Show**.
- ▶ **Ctrl+C** copy, **Ctrl+X** cut (move), **Ctrl+V** paste, **F2** rename, **Alt+Enter** properties.
- ▶ **Delete** sends to the Recycle Bin (restorable); **Shift+Delete** deletes permanently.